
Breaking Free from Big Tech

Digital Sovereignty in an Age of Geopolitical Weaponization

Jack Ruder

April 14, 2026

Abstract

Summary: We are moving from a "digital service" model to a "digital permission" model. This article explores how our reliance on American Big Tech is no longer just a matter of convenience, but a critical vulnerability illustrated by geopolitical sanctions *and the fine print of nonprofit agreements*. Open Source is **the only way out**.

1 The Weaponization of the Cloud

In 2020, a big line was crossed. After investigations into alleged war crimes, the U.S. administration targeted the **International Criminal Court (ICC)**. Sanctions were slapped on ICC officials, and almost overnight, the digital realm turned into a war zone. ICC staff opened their laptops to find their "enterprise" accounts, critical tools for global justice—suddenly, crippled or cut off entirely by Big Tech. The cloud had become a weapon.

This isn't just about a "Google Graveyard" of discontinued apps; it's about the **weaponization of access**. If your entire infrastructure, from emails to legal documents, is hosted by a company subject to the whims of a specific government, your sovereignty is an illusion. You don't own your tools; you are merely a tenant whose lease can be revoked for any or no reason.

2 The Nonprofit Paradox

For People like myself, organising Events for Education as a charitable Initiative/Organisation, the trap is often disguised as a "gift." When setting up a Nonprofit organisation, the temptation to use **Google Workspace for Nonprofits** is immense. It provides "authenticity" and a professional look.

However, a deep dive into the "Additional Terms for Nonprofits" reveals a disturbing reality: Google often reserves the right to access content for "compliance" and "service improvement" in ways that are fundamentally incompatible with confidential work. For a nonprofit dealing with sensitive human rights data or local political organising, this isn't a free tool — **it's a surveillance liability**. Why trust your confidential strategy to a corporation that explicitly states it can look under the hood?

3 Social Media and ActivityPub

The alternative to Social Media is not isolation, but the **Fediverse**. We need to stop talking about "platforms" and start talking about **protocols**¹.

The secret is **ActivityPub**. It is the protocol¹ that makes federation possible. Whether you use **Mastodon** for short-form text or **Pixelfed** for visuals, you are on the same underlying network.

- **Interoperability:** You can follow an "Instagram-style" Pixelfed account directly from your "X-style" Mastodon feed.
- **Ownership:** Because it's decentralised, no single president or CEO can "turn off" the Fediverse.
- **Open Source:** And *if* the organisation behind Mastodon ever decides to stop, you can just fork the repository and still host/develop your own instance

4 The Practical Path: OSS

Breaking free means migrating the foundation. **Linux** over Windows. **LibreOffice** over MS 365. **Nextcloud** over Google Drive. These aren't just technical choices; they are acts of political and personal defiance. They ensure that your digital heritage, and your professional future, cannot be deleted for the sake of profit or at the request of a disgruntled politician.

5 Conclusion

Digital freedom is not found in the settings menu of a trillion-dollar corporation. It is found in the code we own,

¹A protocol is shared specification often created by scientists/engineers, that discuss how the interaction between devices or in the example of ActivityPub clients talk to homeservers and homeservers between each other.

the protocols¹ we share, and the servers we control. It's time to stop asking for permission to exist online.